A Timeline of Typography

Five Centuries of Letterforms — A Font Specimen for OCR Audit

Each section is rendered in a known font. Every blurb is set in the font it describes. SVG logos mark companies that made or popularized each typeface.

c. 1530 — The Garamond





Font: fonts.google.com/specimen/EB+Garamond — OFL, Georg Mayr-Duffner

Claude Garamond was a Parisian punchcutter who broke the mold — literally. Before him, printers carved type into wood or imported it from Italy. Garamond created the first commercially available metal typefaces, and their elegant proportions became the template that defined Roman letterforms for 500 years.

Bold: The quick brown fox jumps over 1,234,567,890 lazy dogs.

Italic: The quick brown fox jumps over 1,234,567,890 lazy dogs.

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Lining figures: 0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9

1722 — The Caslon



Font: fonts.google.com/specimen/Libre+Caslon+Text — OFL, Impallari Type

William Caslon's types were the workhorses of the English-speaking world for a century. The American Declaration of Independence was first printed in Caslon. So was the first edition of Robinson Crusoe. Printers' saying: "When in doubt, use Caslon."

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1757 — The Baskerville



Font: fonts.google.com/specimen/Libre+Baskerville — OFL, Impallari Type

John Baskerville was a Birmingham industrialist who became obsessed with printing. He invented new inks, designed smoother paper, and created typefaces with unprecedented contrast between thick and thin strokes. His contemporaries called his types "too sharp for the eye" — Benjamin Franklin disagreed.

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1798 — The Bodoni



Font: fonts.google.com/specimen/Libre+Bodoni — OFL, Impallari Type

Giambattista Bodoni pushed the contrast dial to eleven. His types feature razor-thin hairlines and dramatic thick verticals — a style later called "Modern." Bodoni's Manuale Tipografico contained 142 typefaces and remains one of the most beautiful type specimens ever printed. Vogue magazine still uses a Bodoni variant for its masthead.

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1845 — The Slab Serif

Font: fonts.google.com/specimen/Zilla+Slab — OFL, Typotheque for Mozilla

The Industrial Revolution needed loud type. Slab serifs — with their blunt, unbracketed serifs of equal weight — were designed to scream from handbills, posters, and newspaper headlines. Mozilla's Zilla Slab carries the tradition forward.

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c. 1895 — The Manual Typewriter

Font: fonts.google.com/specimen/Special+Elite — OFL, Astigmatic (manual typewriter recreation)

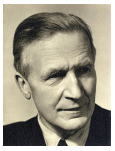
Before electricity, every keystroke was muscle. The Remington No. 2 (1878) introduced the QWERTY layout and the shift key. Underwood No. 5 (1900) made the typebar visible. By 1900, thousands of typists hammered out correspondence on machines that cost a year's wages. The uneven impression, ink buildup, and worn ribbons were not defects — they were the texture of written communication for 80 years.

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1927 — Futura



Font: fonts.google.com/specimen/Jost — OFL, Owen Earl (Futura stand-in)

Paul Renner designed Futura in 1927 for the Bauer foundry. Its near-perfect geometric circles and triangles were radical. Stanley Kubrick used it in 2001. Wes Anderson uses it in everything. And in 1969, it went to the moon on the Apollo 11 plaque. Jost (by Owen Earl) is a faithful open-source stand-in.

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1931 — Times New Roman



Font: Bundled with Windows/Office — Monotype

In 1931, The Times of London commissioned Stanley Morison to redesign their newspaper type. Working with draftsman Victor Lardent, Morison created Times New Roman — optimized for narrow columns and cheap newsprint. Seven decades later, Microsoft bundled it with Windows, and every college student's essay defaulted to it.

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1953 — Prestige Elite

Font: Originally for IBM Executive typewriters — 12 characters per inch

Prestige Elite was the other standard typewriter typeface — the smaller, tighter sibling to Courier's 10 characters per inch. At 12 cpi, Prestige Elite fit more words per line, making it the default for business correspondence, invoices, and government forms. If Courier was the Hollywood typewriter, Prestige Elite was the office workhorse.

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1955 — Courier (IBM)

Font: IBM origin — Bundled with Windows/Office

Howard "Bud" Kettler designed Courier in 1955 for IBM's Selectric typewriters. IBM deliberately chose not to trademark it, making it freely available. Every monospaced terminal, screenplay, and government form owes something to Courier. Its fixed-width design means every character occupies exactly the same horizontal space.

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1957 — Helvetica / Nimbus Sans

Font: URW++ Helvetica clone — fonts.urwpp.de

Max Miedinger and Eduard Hoffmann designed Neue Haas Grotesk in 1957, renaming it Helvetica in 1960. It became the face of corporate modernism — used by American Airlines, Jeep, Toyota, and the NYC subway. Nimbus Sans is URW's Helvetica-compatible libre clone.

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1982 — Arial (Microsoft)

Font: Bundled with Windows/Office — Monotype

Arial was Monotype's strategic masterstroke: a Helvetica substitute with matching metrics but just enough differences to avoid licensing. Microsoft bundled it with Windows 3.1 in 1992 and it conquered the world. Three billion people have used it.

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1993 — Georgia (Microsoft)



Font: Bundled with Windows/Office — Matthew Carter

Matthew Carter created Georgia in 1993 specifically for screen readability. Named after a tabloid headline ('Alien Heads Found in Georgia'), it was one of the first fonts designed from the pixel grid up rather than adapted from print. Carter also designed Verdana, Bell Centennial, and Miller.

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1996 — Verdana (Microsoft)



Font: Bundled with Windows/Office — Matthew Carter

Verdana is Georgia's sans-serif sibling, also by Matthew Carter, also designed for screens. The wide letterforms and tall x-height made it supremely legible on 640×480 monitors. At 10px on a CRT, Verdana was more readable than anything else alive.

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1994 — Comic Sans (Microsoft)



Font: Bundled with Windows/Office — Vincent Connare

Vincent Connare designed Comic Sans in 1994 after seeing Times New Roman in a Microsoft Bob speech bubble. He based it on The Dark Knight Returns and Watchmen lettering. It was never intended for body text — but users put it everywhere: office memos, funeral programs, CERN's Higgs boson announcement. Typographers weep.

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1996 — Trebuchet MS



Font: Bundled with Windows/Office — Vincent Connare

Vincent Connare also designed Trebuchet MS. Named after a medieval siege engine because 'it launches words across the internet,' it occupies a peculiar middle ground: more personality than Arial, less chaos than Comic Sans.

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2004 — The ClearType Collection

Font: fonts.google.com/specimen/Caladea — OFL, Carolina Giovagnoli (Cambria-compatible)

When Microsoft developed ClearType subpixel rendering for LCD screens, they commissioned six new C-named font families: Calibri, Cambria, Candara, Consolas, Constantia, and Corbel. Calibri replaced Times New Roman as the Office default in 2007. Caladea is an open-source metric-compatible Cambria substitute.

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2010 — Roboto (Google)



Font: fonts.google.com/specimen/Roboto — Apache 2.0, Christian Robertson for Google

When Google launched Google Fonts in 2010, it broke the foundry cartel overnight. Christian Robertson's Roboto became Android's system font and the most popular Google Font by a cosmic margin — it's on 27 million websites. Google's Material Design is built on Roboto's proportions.

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2010 — Open Sans (Google)



Font: fonts.google.com/specimen/Open+Sans — OFL, Steve Matteson for Google

Steve Matteson designed Open Sans in 2011, commissioned by Google. Its open apertures and neutral forms make it the typographic equivalent of clean water. WordPress.com and countless government sites use it. The second most popular Google Font.

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2010 — Lato



Font: fonts.google.com/specimen/Lato — OFL, Łukasz Dziedzic

Łukasz Dziedzic designed Lato ('Summer' in Polish) in 2010, originally as a corporate typeface for a client who went in a different direction. Their loss. Lato's semi-rounded details give it warmth without sacrificing seriousness. Third most popular Google Font.

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2011 — Merriweather



Font: fonts.google.com/specimen/Merriweather — OFL, Eben Sorkin

Eben Sorkin designed Merriweather for comfortable reading on screens — large x-height, slightly condensed letterforms, sturdy serifs that don't crumble at small sizes. Named after a 19th-century Kansas newspaper editor. The go-to serif for long blog posts.

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2012 — Source Sans Pro (Adobe)



Font: fonts.google.com/specimen/Source+Sans+3 — OFL, Paul Hunt for Adobe

Paul Hunt designed Source Sans Pro as Adobe's first open-source typeface, released in 2012. It was a signal: even Adobe saw the value of open fonts. Source Sans is a clean humanist sans. Its companion, Source Code Pro, is beloved by programmers.

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2014 — Source Serif 4 (Adobe)

Font: fonts.google.com/specimen/Source+Serif+4 — OFL, Frank Grießhammer for Adobe

Frank Grießhammer's Source Serif bridges the gap between old-style and transitional designs. UC Berkeley uses it as their official serif typeface. Source Serif 4 ships with extensive OpenType features — old-style figures, small caps, and stylistic sets.

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2014 — Noto Serif (Google + Monotype)

Font: fonts.google.com/specimen/Noto+Serif — OFL, Google + Monotype

The Noto project is Google's audacious attempt to create fonts for every writing system in Unicode — 'No Tofu' (the nickname for □ missing-glyph boxes). It covers 146 scripts and 800+ languages. The most democratic type project ever attempted.

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2009 — PT Serif (ParaType)



Font: fonts.google.com/specimen/PT+Serif — OFL, Alexandra Korolkova at ParaType

PT Serif was commissioned by the Russian government to create a public font family covering all the languages of the Russian Federation. Designed by Alexandra Korolkova at ParaType. State-funded type for the public good.

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2011 — Playfair Display



Font: fonts.google.com/specimen/Playfair+Display — OFL, Claus Eggers Sørensen

Claus Eggers Sørensen designed Playfair Display as a nod to the high-contrast types of the Enlightenment — Baskerville, Bodoni, and the Didots. Its delicate hairlines make it a display face par excellence: magazine headings, wedding invitations. Not great below 14px, but for titles at 36pt+, Playfair is magnificent.

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2017 — IBM Plex Sans



Font: fonts.google.com/specimen/IBM+Plex+Sans — OFL, Mike Abbink + Bold Monday for IBM

When IBM replaced Helvetica Neue with IBM Plex in 2017, it was a $100B company saying 'we need our own voice.' Plex threads a needle between Helvetica's neutrality and Futura's geometry. Corporate type that actually cares about craft.

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2017 — IBM Plex Serif



Font: fonts.google.com/specimen/IBM+Plex+Serif — OFL, Mike Abbink + Bold Monday for IBM

IBM Plex Serif is the quieter sibling — a contemporary slab-influenced serif that pairs naturally with Plex Sans. Together, the Plex family demonstrates that corporate identity fonts don't have to be boring.

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2017 — IBM Plex Mono



Font: fonts.google.com/specimen/IBM+Plex+Mono — OFL, Mike Abbink + Bold Monday for IBM

IBM Plex Mono completes the Plex trilogy with a monospaced design that nods to IBM's original Selectric typefaces. Its distinctive glyph shapes make zero/O and one/l/I instantly distinguishable — the single most important trait in a programming font.

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2018 — Inter (Rasmus Andersson)



Font: fonts.google.com/specimen/Inter — OFL, Rasmus Andersson. Also rsms.me/inter

Rasmus Andersson, a designer at Figma, created Inter for user interfaces — specifically, for the awkward sizes between 11px and 16px. Its tall x-height and extensive kerning pairs make it the default for design tools and dashboards. It's what Helvetica would be if Helvetica were designed for Retina screens.

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